

# Performance and Development Cycle

Version 4.5 | Owner: People Operations | Effective 2026-01-01 | Next review 2027-01-01

## 1. Purpose

How performance is discussed, recorded and rewarded at Zuqah Technologies. The cycle exists to make sure feedback is regular and expectations are explicit — not to generate a rating.

## 2. The cycle

| When    | What                        | Who                            |
|---------|-----------------------------|--------------------------------|
| January | Objectives set for the year | Employee and manager           |
| April   | Light check-in              | Employee and manager           |
| July    | Mid-year review, formal     | Employee and manager           |
| October | Light check-in              | Employee and manager           |
| January | Year-end review and rating  | Employee, manager, calibration |

Between these, a monthly one-to-one is expected. The formal points exist to catch anything the monthly conversation has missed; they are not the primary mechanism for feedback, and nothing raised at a formal review should be a surprise.

## 3. Objectives

Three to five objectives per year, agreed rather than assigned. Each should be specific enough that both people would agree at year end whether it was met.

Objectives cover:

- Delivery — client work and its outcomes
- Contribution — what you added beyond your own engagements
- Development — what you set out to learn

Objectives can be changed during the year. An engagement ending or a role changing is a reason to revise them, not a reason to be measured against something that no longer applies.

## 4. Ratings

Five ratings, applied at year end only.

| Rating      | Meaning                                                              |
|-------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Exceptional | Consistently beyond the level; visible impact beyond own engagements |
| Strong      | Fully meets the level, with some areas beyond it                     |
| Effective   | Meets the level. The expected outcome for most people                |
| Developing  | Meets some of the level; a clear plan is in place                    |
| Below       | Does not meet the level; a formal improvement plan applies           |

Effective is a good rating. It means a person is doing the job they are paid to do, well. Most people receive it, and it is not a signal of concern.

There is no forced distribution. Calibration compares how the level is applied between managers; it does not fit ratings to a curve.

## 5. Calibration

Managers within a practice meet each January to review proposed ratings together. The purpose is consistency — that "Strong" means the same thing across the practice — not to move people between ratings to hit a target.

Calibration outcomes are shared with the employee by their manager, with the reasoning.

## 6. Promotion

Promotion is considered at year end and is separate from rating. A promotion requires that the person is already working consistently at the next level, not that they are ready to try it.

Promotion cases are prepared by the manager and reviewed at practice level. An unsuccessful case comes with specific, written feedback on what is missing. "Not this year" without a reason is not an acceptable outcome, and should be escalated to People Operations if it happens.

## 7. Compensation review

Compensation is reviewed annually, effective 1 April, and takes into account rating, level, market position and time at level. It is communicated in March.

Compensation is not discussed during the review conversation itself, deliberately — it makes the development conversation harder and less honest.

## 8. Feedback

Feedback can be requested from anyone, at any time, through the HR portal. Zuqah Technologies encourages requesting it directly rather than only through the cycle.

At year end, managers gather feedback from engagement leads. Employees may nominate additional people. Feedback is shared with the employee in substance, though not always attributed.

## **9. Improvement plans**

Where performance is materially below the level, a formal improvement plan is agreed. It is written, has a defined period — normally three months — and states specifically what needs to change and how it will be measured.

An improvement plan is a genuine attempt to resolve a problem, and the majority conclude successfully. It is not a procedural step towards an exit.

## **10. New starters**

Employees joining after 1 October are not rated in the following January. Their first full cycle begins the year after. Objectives are still set on joining.

this document describes no real organisation's policy.\*

Sample content for demonstration purposes. Zuqah Technologies is a fictional company and this document describes no real organisation's policy.